



RANJAN RAHI

“Will somebody please help me find my family? I escaped but I don't know their fate.”

DINESH SHAH, 39

Labourer, Jirwa

He is not sure what makes him pause, turn and stare blindly; but Shah just looks blankly at the sea of people at a Saharsa relief centre, perhaps scanning them for a few identifiable faces. Perhaps, because he knows that those he was searching for couldn't just be there. He left them—three daughters, all of 14, 12 and 2 and two sons, aged 9 and 5, besides wife America Devi, parents, two sisters (one of them pregnant) and their families—at Jirwa village under Pathalghat block of Saharsa under exploding Kosi waters and a crashing thatched roof. “It was the dead of night when I heard the monstrous waves invading my nondescript home. My children, who were asleep, were suddenly floating and then the roof came down. I was terribly scared and swam like a mad man before I realised I had left behind everybody else,” he says in a choked voice. He preferred life, little knowing that without his family it would be worse than death.

the setting up of the disaster management teams at the Centre and states. The activation of the response has been swift but as the crisis continues, only time will tell about the quality of our response,” says Lt General J.R. Bharadwaj, member, NDMA.

The NDRF men—flown in from Orissa where they are normally stationed—and their boats were clearly inadequate. Take the case of inflatable boats or Geminis, lifesavers in Bihar's flood relief operations. The NDMA envisaged each of its eight NDRF battalions to be equipped with 114 boats. Since the sole manufacturer it has contracted, a Noida-based firm that produces only 15 boats per year, all eight battalions have just over 100 boats. So the armed forces had to be called in and it was on September 2, two weeks after the tragedy first struck, that relief and rescue operations went in full swing. Prime Minister Manmohan Singh, who did an aerial recce of the area, called it a “national catastrophe” and announced Central assistance of Rs 1,000 crore.

Meanwhile, the man who has come in for the most flak for the crisis, and deservedly so, is the